

@eek-MAIL

10 e-mail disasters to avoid

A slip of a click is all it takes for that e-mail to turn back and hit you where it hurts the most. Here are some of the most mortifying e-mail blunders that we could dig up and the precautions you can take to avoid embarrassment. All personal names have been omitted or changed to protect the embarrassed.

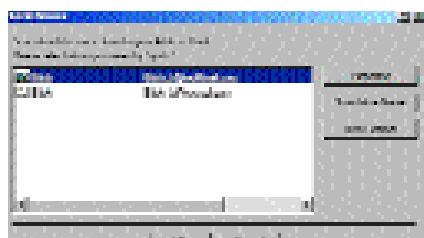
1 Buddy who?

Many e-mail clients allow you to specify nicknames or use the autocomplete feature to fill in the e-mail address. But what if you have two people with the same name in your address book? Or if the person has two e-mail IDs and you accidentally send a mail to the ID that he doesn't check too often? Many e-mail programs even add the default domain name of your ISP if you don't specify the full e-mail address and if a match isn't present in the address book.

This can cause you no little embarrassment, as Mr Dude-at-large found out the hard way. He wanted tips on impressing the girls at the office party from a friend, all through e-mail. Little did he realise that the mail addressed to buddy@somewebmail.com was actually sent off to his supervisor, buddy@company.com.



Workaround: Double-check the 'To:' field before you send a mail. You can use the shortcut [Ctrl] + [K] to check the exact e-mail address



If you aren't careful, you can end up sending the e-mail to the wrong person with the same name

of all those you've added to the 'To:' field. Or better still, keep 'Autocomplete' off. In Outlook Express, select **Tools > Options > Send**. Here unselect the checkbox 'Automatically complete e-mail addresses when composing'.

2 For all to see

The sins of the 'Reply All' button are quite common—we see examples of it every day. Some manager sends an e-mail to everybody announcing a promotion in the office and then people start sending congratulatory messages to the promotee, and all mails are sent Reply All. So everybody in the mailing list gets to know how Mr Sharma is delighted to welcome Mr Singh in the team and how Mr Gupta agrees with Mr Sharma that Mr Gupta will indeed be a great asset to the team.



Having the 'Reply All' button next to 'Reply' is the perfect recipe for disaster

Now this kind of e-mail would rate as a minor irritant. We can live with that. But there is every chance that an indiscriminate use of the 'Reply All' button could lead to an embarrassing situation.

One of the most embarrassing incidents we know of is when this client mailed a change in project requirements to the people working on his project. Miffed at the change in plan, which would require working to a tighter deadline, one team member sent a detailed mail to her colleague cribbing about the whole deal and what exactly she thought about the client. Soon there was mail flying back and forth with snide comments about the client and the project. Little did the two realise that all this while they'd been sending the mail Reply All. Needless to say, the company lost that account and the two ladies just about managed to save their job.



Workaround: Remove the 'Reply All' button from the layout. This will ensure that you use it only when you want it. Right-click on the taskbar and then click on 'Customize'. In the window that comes up, click on 'Reply All' in the right pane and then click on 'Remove'. Now click 'Apply' and you are safe.

Also, watch your To's and CC's when replying to mail. Don't continue to include people if the message becomes a private conversation.

3 Looking high and low...

Admin-All has a similar potential to go awry as the deadly 'Reply All' button. One of the worst incidents we witnessed was of a person who misplaced his screwdriver and shot off an e-mail asking the unknown person who had borrowed it, to return it. The catch was that instead of clicking on Admin-Local, he clicked on Admin-All and the e-mail was sent to over 200 people, including the branch offices across India! For weeks afterwards our hero received mail about the likely adventures that the truant screwdriver could be having.

On a more serious note, the Admin-All feature has great potential for misuse. Disgruntled employees can and do use it to vent spleen about management policies, which can be demoralising for the rest of the team.



Workaround: It is much wiser to simply disable Admin-All from the address book. Sure, one can still send mail to everyone in the office, but the chances are much less if one has to manually enter each address in the 'To:' field.